



Change of setting: Naomi Osaka split with coach Wim Fissette and hired Tomas Wiktorowski, Iga Swiatek's former coach. REUTERS

Aryna Sabalenka, a relentless power hitter like Sinner, won the two hard-court majors in 2024 and finished the year ranked No. 1. But unlike Sinner, who consolidated his reign this season, Sabalenka faltered at the Slams. The Belarusian Basher lost three-set heartbreakers to red-hot American opponents — Madison Keys at the Australian Open, Coco Gauff at Roland Garros, and Amanda Anisimova at Wimbledon.

Keys and Gauff prevailed in the finals. Anisimova's ecstasy after her stunning semifinal upset of Sabalenka turned into agony two days later when the resurgent Iga Swiatek double-bageled her in the Wimbledon final. Oh, how cruel tennis can be!

Whether you call it parity or depth

in women's tennis, this Grand Slam trend will likely continue at the U.S. Open, which has produced six different champions since Naomi Osaka shocked Serena Williams in the tempestuous 2018 final. The most mind-blowing of them was 18-year-old Emma Raducanu, who in 2021 made history as the first qualifier to win a Grand Slam singles title. *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone said, "It has to be a top-five improbability story in any sport."

My crystal ball predicts another long shot will rock the sporting world with a series of stunning upsets. Let's find out who this year's Cinderella champion will be.

Naomi Osaka — "She needs momentum more than anything else. I'm a huge fan of Naomi Osaka. It's less about the tennis, it's more about what's between the ears," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Prakash Amritraj. Her comeback since returning from maternity leave in 2023 never gained traction during

seven Grand Slam appearances. The most recent disappointment: a Wimbledon third-round loss to Anastasia Pavlyuchenkova. During the prolonged slump, the four-time Major champion, dispirited, contemplated retirement.

Too talented to fail any longer, Osaka — who split with coach Wim Fissette and hired Tomasz Wiktorowski, Swiatek's former coach — finally regained her elite form in Montreal. Slapping her thighs before returning serve to pump herself up, the rejuvenated Japanese surged to the final. The unseeded Osaka outslugged heavy hitters 13th seed Liudmila Samsonova and 22nd seed Jelena Ostapenko, combined power with consistency to trounce 10th seed Elina Svitolina, and outhit 16th seed Clara Tauson to reach her first WTA 1000 final since 2021. There, it took a sensational performance by teenager Victoria Mboko to stop her, 2-6, 6-4, 6-1.

On the 27-year-old's resurgence, *Tennis Channel* analyst Andrea Petkovic noted, "She has an improved serve and a shorter take-back on the backhand, which helps her on the hard courts." With better technique, much-needed momentum, and renewed confidence, Osaka will go deep into the second week at a Major for the first time since she won the 2021 Australian Open.

Clara Tauson — In 2019, Tauson became the first Dane to top the junior world rankings after winning nine ITF singles titles, including the Australian Open. Unlike former No. 1 Caroline Wozniacki, who became the greatest female player in her country's history as a heady and steady baseliner, Tauson epitomises 'Big Babe' tennis. A back injury derailed her promising professional career in 2022, but the low-key, 22-year-old Tauson is finally emerging as a formidable force.

After the 5'11" Tauson stunned Swiatek 7-6(1), 6-3 at the National Bank Open in Montreal, Petkovic said, "Such an impressive performance. Not only the firepower, [but also] the tactics, the slices, the anticipation, the variety." That was no